Cruiser tank
Also called the cavalry tank or fast tank, the cruiser tank was a British concept developed in the interwar period. Light and fast, it was intended to make rapid advances after a breakthrough.

Cupola
A mini turret situated atop the main turret, giving the commander a better view of the battlefield.

Deep battle
A tactical doctrine developed in the interwar period—notably by Mikhail Tukhachevsky in the Soviet Union—that emphasized attacking the enemy throughout the depth of their positions rather than at the front line only. The intention was to quickly break through and destroy vital support facilities such as command units and supply dumps, preventing front-line forces from continuing to fight.

Depleted uranium
An extremely dense material used both in tank armor and in armor-piercing projectiles.

Depression
The extent to which a tank's main gun can be lowered beneath the horizontal. This ability is particularly important when the tank is behind the crest of a hill, with its hull pointing upward. Depression is the opposite of elevation.

Diesel
A liquid fuel that ignites when compressed.

Direct fire
Fire aimed at a target that can be seen by the gunner. Direct fire is the opposite of indirect fire.

Ditching
A tank or armored vehicle becoming stuck in a trench or other depression.

Division
A military unit, usually made up of a number of brigades. Containing their own logistical units, divisions are generally the smallest units capable of independent operations on the battlefield. Their strength is usually around 20,000 men.

Driver
The tank crewman responsible for driving the vehicle.

Echelon
A formation of tanks arranged diagonally. Following vehicles are either positioned to the rear and right (right cchelon) or left (left echelon) of the leader.

Electronic Countermeasures (ECM)
Electronic devices used to disrupt and deceive enemy detection, communication, or signaling systems. Their functions include making targets invisible to sensors, jamming communications, and preventing the activation of roadside bombs.

Elevation
The extent to which a tank's main gun can be raised above the horizontal; the greater the angle, the greater the range. Elevation is the opposite of depression.

Enfilade
Gunfire aimed along an enemy position from end to end. In World War I, trenches were vulnerable to such attack, especially from tanks, and so were dug in a zigzag fashion.

Explosive Reactive Armor (ERA)
See *Reactive armor*.

Firing port
A port on the side of an IFV that enables infantry to bring small arms fire to bear without leaving the vehicle.

Flame tank
A type of tank equipped with a flamethrower, usually used in specialized operations, particularly attacks on fortifications.

Flanking maneuver
The movement of an armed force around the side, or flank, of an enemy force to gain tactical advantage.

Fume extractor
A vent on a gun barrel that prevents poisonous fumes from a fired round from leaking back into the crew compartment. It uses the changes in pressure in the barrel to force the fumes out of the muzzle.

Gasoline
Processed oil that is used as a fuel in internal combustion engines.

Glacis plate
The sloped, front-most section of the hull of a tank. Its angle helps deflect projectiles, and presents a greater thickness of armor for a projectile striking it horizontally to pass through.

Gradient
The degree of slope up which a tank can travel.

Grousers
Studded or treaded extensions that are added to a tank's tracks to give it greater traction on loose materials such as soil or snow.

Guided munition
Unlike a bullet, which follows a trajectory determined by gravity and its propellant charge only, the flight path of a guided munition can be altered.

Gunsight
An optical device used by gunners to aim with greater accuracy. Telescopic sights for tanks were adopted before World War II.

Gunner
The tank crewman responsible for aiming (or "laying") and firing the main gun.

Half-track
A vehicle with conventional wheels at the front for steering, and a caterpillar track at the rear for propulsion. The design fuses the cross-country capabilities of a tank with the handling of a road vehicle.

Heavy tank
A class of slow but heavily armored tanks designed for infantry support. The very first tanks of World War I were of this class, and became known as "heavies" as lighter, faster, more maneuverable tanks were introduced. Heavy tanks were usually more heavily armed and armored, but slower than other vehicles.

High Explosive (HE)
A type of ammunition that uses explosive blast to affect the target. Types include HE-Frag, HEAT, HESH, and APHE. Modern HE rounds are less effective against tanks, but can still damage or destroy lighter vehicles and are highly effective against unprotected infantry.

High Explosive Fragmentation (HE-Frag)
HE-Frag uses explosive blast and fragmentation to destroy its target. It is most effective against lightly armored targets.

High Explosive Antitank (HEAT)
A HEAT round uses a shaped-charge warhead to form a high-speed jet of molten metal that penetrates armor. Because they do not depend on velocity for their effect, HEAT warheads are commonly affixed to slower munitions, such as missiles and mines.

High Explosive Squash Head (HESH)
A HESH round is a munition used against armored vehicles and fortifications. On impact, the plastic explosive at the head of the round squashes against the surface of the target before exploding. This transmits a shock wave through the armor, causing fragments of steel to detach from the tank interior at high velocity, potentially killing crew members.

High Velocity Armor-Piercing (HVAP)
An armor-piercing round that has a high-density core surrounded by lighter material. The latter reduces weight, enabling higher velocity and greater armor penetration.

Hobart's Funnies
A number of tank variants used by the British 79th Armored Division during World War II. These included tanks modified to carry bridges, mine ploughs, flails, a swimming tank, and engineer vehicles that could destroy fortifications or carry fascines to fill obstacles. They took their name from Major General Sir Percy Hobart, the commander of the division.

Horsepower
A unit of power equal to 550 ft-lb per second (750 watts) used to measure the output of an engine. The term was adopted in the 18th century by British engineer James Watt to compare the output of steam engines with the amount of work performed by a single draft horse.

Horstmann suspension
A type of suspension developed by British engineer Sidney Horstmann in 1922. Featuring coil springs, it was used on the Vickers Light, Centurion, and Chieftain tanks, among others.

Hull
The body of the tank beneath the turret.

Hull-down / Hull-up
When only the turret of a tank is visible above the crest of a hill or another obstacle it is said to be hull-down; when the entire body is visible it is said to be hull-up.

Humvee
The High Mobility Multipurpose Wheeled Vehicle (HMMWV) is a four-wheel drive military light truck that came of age during the First Gulf War.

Hydropneumatic suspension
A form of suspension that uses oil and pneumatic pressure to keep a vehicle level.

Idler
A nondriven end wheel of a tracked vehicle that serves to adjust track tension.

Improvised Explosive Device (IED)
A bomb constructed in an improvised manner rather than being designed for the purpose. IEDs can be made from chemicals such as fertilizer, or make use of adapted mines or artillery shells. They are also known as roadside bombs.

Indirect fire
Fire aimed at a target that cannot be seen by the gunner. It usually requires a separate forward observer to correct the aim. Indirect fire is the opposite of direct fire.

Infantry Fighting Vehicle (IFV)
A type of AFV used to carry infantry to the battlefield. Unlike APCs, IFVs are able to enter combat, possessing heavier armor and armament, which sometimes includes antitank weaponry, and very often firing ports that allow the infantry to fight from inside the vehicle.